

14 > Your Home Screen

buds and watch levels. A giant decorative clock that duplicates the lock screen may be beautiful, but beauty alone is expensive on a small screen.

The rule is simple: if you do not read or use the widget daily, remove it.

Step-by-step: add a genuinely useful widget

- Long-press an empty area on the home screen.
- Tap Widgets.
- Scroll to the app you want, such as Calendar, Keep, Tasks, Weather, Google, Clock or Battery.
- Tap the app to see available widget sizes.
- Long-press the widget and drag it to your home screen.
- Resize it if your launcher allows resizing.
- Place it where your eyes naturally land.
- Use it for two days. If you ignore it, remove it.

This last step is important. Widgets are experiments. Do not keep failed experiments out of guilt.

App shortcuts: the hidden home-screen weapon

Many Android apps support shortcuts when you long-press the app icon. These can open specific actions directly. The Android developer documentation explains that app shortcuts are designed to help users quickly start common or recommended tasks inside an app, and they can appear in supported launchers or assistants.

For users, this is gold. Long-press WhatsApp and you may see recent chats. Long-press Camera and you may see selfie or video options. Long-press Maps and you may get directions shortcuts. Long-press Phone and you may see frequent contacts. Long-press many UPI or payment apps and you may get quick actions, depending on app support and launcher behaviour.

Some shortcuts can also be dragged to the home screen as standalone icons. That means instead of opening WhatsApp, searching for your family group, and then typing, you can create a direct shortcut to that chat. Instead of opening Maps and typing home, you can create a shortcut for navigation. Instead of opening a notes app and choosing a list, you can jump straight to the list.

This is where Android starts feeling less like a phone and more like a command centre.

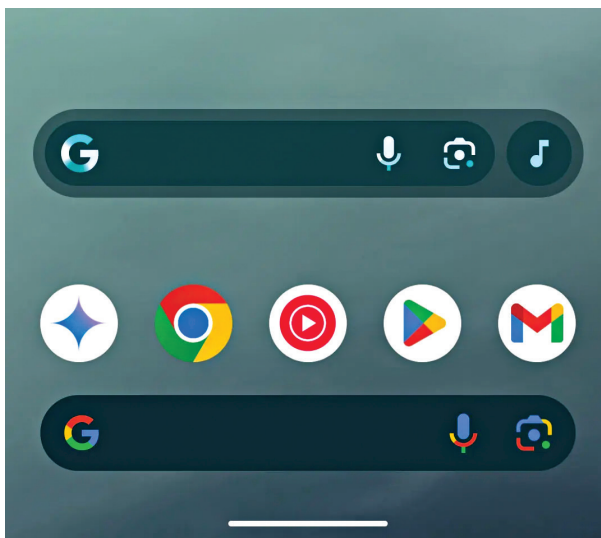
Step-by-step: create an app shortcut

- Find the app icon on your home screen or app drawer.
- Long-press the icon.
- Look for quick actions that appear above or beside it.
- Touch and hold the specific shortcut you want.
- Drag it to your home screen.
- Place it in a useful position or inside an action-based folder.
- Test it once.

Try this with WhatsApp, Maps, Camera, Calendar, Keep, Drive, Phone and your most-used payment app. Not every app will offer useful shortcuts, but the ones that do can save dozens of taps a week.

The search bar is underrated

Many users remove the Google search bar to make the home screen look cleaner. That is fine if they replace it with a better search habit. But for most people, search is faster than hunting. A good search bar can help you search the web, open apps, find contacts, ask voice queries, use Lens, and start quick information checks.



Google's Android guidance for the search widget explains that users can add the widget to the home screen and customise its colour, shape and transparency from the Google app settings. This matters because a search bar does not have to ruin your layout. It can blend in and still remain useful.

For Indian users, search is often the fastest bridge across languages and tasks. You may search for a government form, a train status, a local shop, a Hindi phrase, a cricket score, a translation, a nearby ATM or a forgotten app. Keeping search close is rarely a bad idea.

Material You: make beauty functional

Android's visual identity has changed significantly since Android 12, when Google introduced Material You. The Android Open Source Project describes Material You as focusing on expression and fluidity, helping users create a cohesive experience around dynamic colour, motion and widgets. Dynamic colour can derive colours from your wallpaper and apply them across parts of the system and supported apps.

This is not only cosmetic. A visually coherent phone can be easier to read and calmer to use. But do not let theming become